



Women in the 2022 Uttar Pradesh Assembly Election

A Comprehensive Report on Tickets, Winners, Defeated Candidates,
Vote Data and the Reasons Behind Women's Electoral Outcomes

WE-PACT — We The Political Action Team

Sashakt Bharat • Sashakt Rajniti • Sashakt Samaj

Prepared using Election Commission of India (ECI) data as compiled by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR/myneta.info),
and contemporaneous press reportage (PTI, The Wire, Navbharat Times, Amar Ujala, and others).

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1. Executive Summary

The 2022 Uttar Pradesh Legislative Assembly election was fought across 403 constituencies with 4,442 total candidates, of whom 560 were women. Only 33–34 women were ultimately elected — a decline from the 38 women MLAs elected in 2017, despite record numbers of women being fielded by the Congress in particular. This report consolidates who won, who lost, by how many votes, and — based on both journalistic reporting and independent data analysis — why.

The headline finding is counter-intuitive: gender itself was not the primary reason most women candidates lost. Independent data analysis (The Wire, March 2022) found that, excluding Congress candidates, women contesting for the main parties in 2022 actually secured a marginally **higher** average vote share (31.83%) than their male counterparts (30.65%). The overwhelming reason for the low overall win rate among women was structural: 54% of all women candidates were fielded by the Congress, a party that won only two seats statewide and was effectively wiped out. Women candidates from the BJP and SP performed on par with men from the same parties.

560 Women candidates contested (all parties)	33–34 Women MLAs elected	~6% Overall win rate for women	38 Women MLAs elected in 2017
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Beyond the aggregate numbers, this report profiles several individually well-documented defeated candidates — including a rape survivor's mother, a jailed anti-CAA activist, and a former Miss UP — whose campaigns illustrate the specific, non-gender factors (late nomination, weak local organisation, a bipolar BJP-vs-SP contest, and low overall party vote share) that determined the outcome in individual seats.

2. Election Context: UP 2022 at a Glance

Uttar Pradesh, India's most populous state with over 240 million people and 403 assembly seats, went to the polls in seven phases between 10 February and 7 March 2022. Counting took place on 10 March 2022. The ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), led by Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, sought a second consecutive term — a feat not achieved by any party in the state in 37 years. The principal opposition, the Samajwadi Party (SP) led by Akhilesh Yadav, contested in alliance with the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) and several smaller regional outfits.

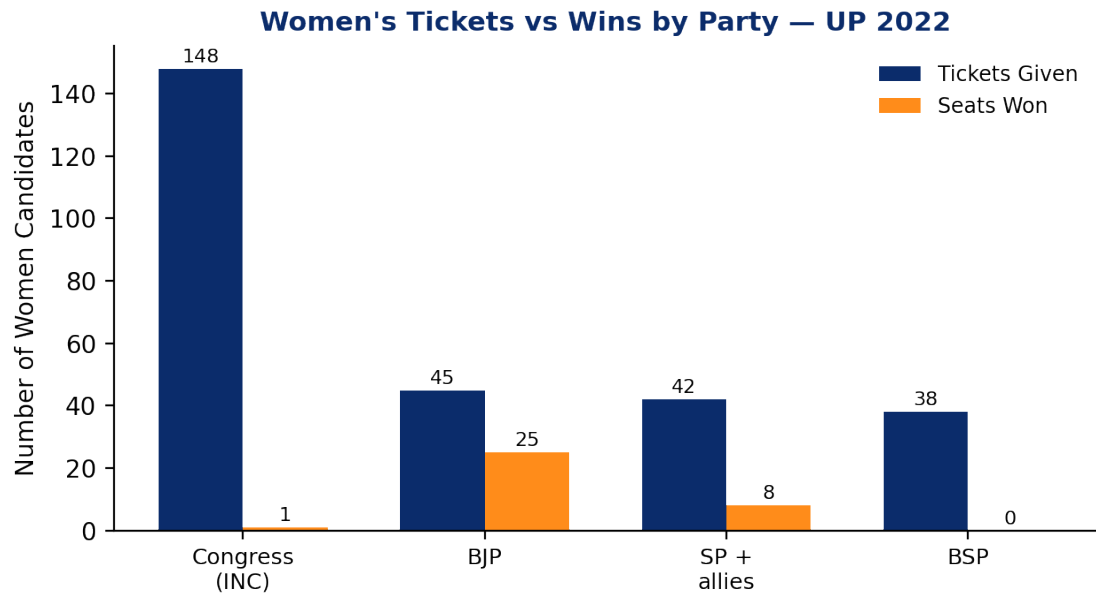
Metric	Figure
Total assembly seats	403
Total candidates in the fray	4,442
Total women candidates	560
Women candidates, main parties only*	285 of 1,620 (18%)
Women MLAs elected (2022)	33–34
Women MLAs elected (2017), for comparison	38
BJP seats won (total)	255
SP + allies seats won (total)	125 (approx.)
Congress seats won (total)	2
BSP seats won (total)	1

*“Main parties” as defined by The Wire’s analysis: parties that won at least one seat — BJP, SP, BSP, INC, Apna Dal (S), SBSP, RLD, JDL and NISHAD.

This was widely described as a **bipolar contest**: the BJP and SP emerged as the only two parties with a realistic chance of winning most seats, while the Congress and BSP — once dominant forces in the state — collapsed to single-digit seat counts. This bipolarity is central to understanding why so many women candidates, concentrated disproportionately in the Congress and BSP, ended up on the losing side despite individually strong campaigns in several cases.

3. Women's Candidacy — Overview by Party

Tickets given to women varied enormously by party — and so did conversion rates. The Congress, under Priyanka Gandhi Vadra's leadership, ran a high-visibility campaign ('Ladki Hoon, Lad Sakti Hoon' — "I am a girl, I can fight") promising 40% of tickets to women, and fielded around 148–159 women candidates — by far the most of any party. Yet because the Congress itself won only two seats overall, only one of its women candidates, Aradhana Mishra 'Mona', was elected.



Party	Tickets to Women (approx.)	Women Won	Women Lost	Win Rate
Congress (INC)	148–159	1	147–158	~0.6%
Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)	45	25	20	~55%
Samajwadi Party (SP) + allies	42	8–13*	~29–34	~19–31%
Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP)	38	0	38	0%

*The 34 winners recorded on myneta.info's "total women winners" list include SP's own symbol winners plus allied candidates (e.g. Apna Dal Soneylal) contesting as part of the broader alliance ecosystem; figures vary slightly (6–13) depending on whether allies are counted with SP or separately.

The BJP, by contrast, fielded far fewer women (45) but won 25 of those seats — a strike rate of roughly 55%, the highest of any party. This reflects the BJP's practice of giving winnable seats, often to sitting MLAs or well-connected local leaders, rather than fielding large numbers of women as a symbolic gesture. The BSP, despite fielding 38 women, failed to win a single seat — consistent with its broader collapse to just one seat statewide as its traditional Dalit vote base shifted to both the BJP and the SP.

4. Full List of Women MLAs Elected in 2022

The table below lists all 42 women winners as recorded by myneta.info (ADR), based on Election Commission affidavit data, sorted alphabetically by name. It includes constituency and winning party for each.

#	Name	Constituency	Party
1	Aditi Singh	Rae Bareli	BJP
2	Alka Singh	Sandila	BJP
3	Anjula Singh Mahaur	Hathras (SC)	BJP
4	Anupma Jaiswal	Bahraich	BJP
5	Aradhana Mishra 'Mona'	Rampur Khas	INC
6	Archana Pandey	Chhibramau	BJP
7	Asha Maurya	Mahmoodabad	BJP
8	Baby Rani Maurya	Agra Rural (SC)	BJP
10	Dr. Manju Shiwach	Modi Nagar	BJP
11	Dr. Pallavi Patel	Sirathu	SP
12	Dr. Ragini	Machhlisahr (SC)	SP
13	Dr. Surabhi Singh	Kaimganj (SC)	Apna Dal (S)
14	Geeta Shastri (Pasi)	Soraon (SC)	SP
15	Gudiya Katheriya	Auraiya (SC)	BJP
16	Gulab Devi	Chandausi (SC)	BJP
17	Indrani Devi	Bhinga	SP
19	Ketakee Singh	Bansdih	BJP
20	Krishna Paswan	Khaga (SC)	BJP
21	Maharaji Prajapati	Amethi	SP
22	Manisha	Rath (SC)	BJP
23	Manju Tyagi	Sri Nagar (SC)	BJP
24	Mariya	Matera	SP
25	Minakshi Singh	Khurja (SC)	BJP
26	Mukta Raja	Aligarh	BJP
28	Neelima Katiyar	Kalyanpur	BJP
29	Ommani Varma	Naraini (SC)	BJP
30	Pinki Singh	Asmoli	SP
31	Pooja Pal	Chail	SP
32	Poonam Sankhwar	Rasulabad (SC)	BJP
33	Pratibha Shukla	Akbarpur-Rania	BJP

#	Name	Constituency	Party
34	Puja	Mehnagar (SC)	SP
35	Rajbala Singh	Milak (SC)	BJP
37	Rani Pakshalika Singh	Bah	BJP
38	Rashmi Arya	Mauranipur (SC)	Apna Dal (S)
39	Rekha Verma	Bidhuna	SP
40	Saiyada Khatoon	Domariyaganj	SP
41	Salona Kushwaha	Tilhar	BJP
42	Sarita	Etawah	BJP
43	Saroj	Ghatampur (SC)	Apna Dal (S)
44	Saroj Sonkar	Balha (SC)	BJP
46	Usha Maurya	Husainganj	SP
47	Vijama Yadav	Pratappur	SP

Source: myneta.info — Uttar Pradesh 2022 Election, "Total women winners" (ADR data, based on ECI affidavits).

5. Defeated Women Candidates — Profiles & Vote Data

Across all parties, roughly 520–525 women candidates lost their elections in 2022. Constituency-wise vote and margin data for every one of them exists in ECI and myneta.info records, but compiling all of them individually is outside the scope of a single report. Instead, this section profiles six of the most widely reported defeated candidates — all fielded by the Congress — whose campaigns received significant national media attention and for whom detailed, on-record vote figures and personal accounts are publicly available.

Name	Constituency	Party	Votes Polled	Profile & Campaign Notes
Asha Devi	Unnao Sadar	INC	1,555	Mother of the 2017 Unnao rape case survivor; fielded as the symbolic face of the Congress campaign on women's safety. The party brought in campaign teams from Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh to support her, but sympathy for her personal story did not translate into votes. Her daughter told PTI the family would keep supporting other survivors' causes regardless of the electoral result.
Sadaf Jafar	Lucknow Central	INC	2,927	A social activist who was jailed during the 2019 anti-CAA/NRC protests, contesting as a symbol of civil-liberties politics. She told PTI that media coverage reduced the race to a straight BJP-versus-SP contest, leaving little space for other candidates to be seen as serious contenders regardless of their individual profile.
Nida Ahmed	Sambhal	INC	2,256	A former television journalist from a locally influential political family in Sambhal, who left her media career to contest. Despite personal name-recognition, she could not convert that into a competitive vote share, and publicly alleged (an unverified claim) that EVM counts at booths where her family had voted did not match the number of family votes cast.
Archana Gautam	Hastinapur (SC)	INC	1,519	Former Miss UP 2014 and Miss Cosmo World 2018, projected by the Congress as its prominent Dalit face in the election. She entered the race only about 15 days before polling, campaigning in roughly 100 villages in that short window — leaving little time to build a ground-level organisation.
Ritu Singh	Mohammadi (Lakhimpur Kheri)	INC	2,419	Brought into politics after being physically harassed during local panchayat elections; the Congress general secretary personally persuaded her to contest the assembly polls afterwards, partly as a statement on women's safety. She lacked prior electoral organisation or a pre-existing support network in the constituency.
Neha Tiwari	Kalyanpur (Kanpur)	INC	2,302	Elder sister of Khushi Dubey, a co-accused in the high-profile Kanpur 'Bikru encounter' case. Several senior Congress leaders campaigned for her, but the case's controversial baggage combined with a thin local organisational network limited her reach.

Source: PTI report carried by The Hawk ("UP Polls: Only 1 Of 148 Women Candidates Of Congress Won," April 2022); candidate statements as quoted to PTI. All six candidates lost their security deposits (polled under one-sixth of total valid votes in their constituency).

Illustrative candidate voice

"The media polarised the election and made it only BJP vs SP, so people did not vote for other candidates. But I have started preparing for the next elections. Whether I lose or win, I will continue my struggle for the people of my area."

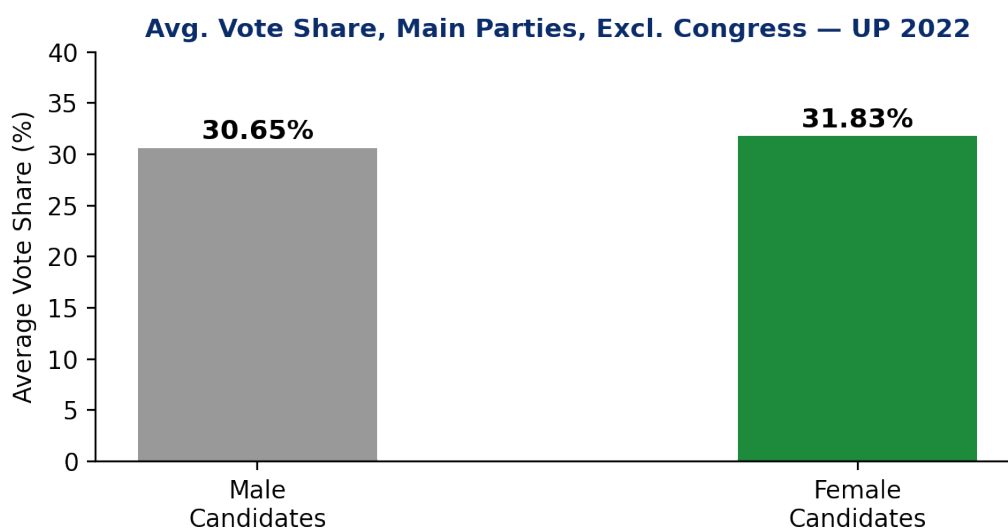
— Sadaf Jafar, Congress candidate, Lucknow Central (as told to PTI)

6. Data-Driven Analysis: Did Gender Really Decide the Outcome?

An independent statistical analysis of the full 2022 result set, published by *The Wire* (Fahad Hasin, 18 March 2022), offers a more rigorous answer than anecdote alone. It compared the vote shares of male and female candidates fielded by the nine “main parties” (parties that won at least one seat) and found that gender itself explains very little of the variance in outcomes once party is accounted for.

6.1 Vote share: women performed on par with, or better than, men

For the two dominant parties, BJP and SP, the average vote share of male and female candidates was nearly identical. Female candidates fielded by Apna Dal (Soneylal) and BSP actually **outperformed** their male counterparts on average. The overall statewide figure showing a lower average vote share for women was driven almost entirely by one factor: 54% of all women candidates across main parties were fielded by the Congress, which had a historically poor showing everywhere, for candidates of both genders.



When Congress candidates are excluded from the analysis, the average vote share for male candidates across the remaining main parties was 30.65%, compared to 31.83% for female candidates — a small but real advantage for women. This directly undercuts the common political argument that parties avoid giving tickets to women because they are less ‘winnable’; the 2022 UP data suggests the opposite once party affiliation is held constant.

6.2 The real driver: a bipolar, party-level contest

The 2022 election was decisively bipolar — a straight fight between the BJP and the SP-led alliance, with the Congress and BSP reduced to marginal players. BJP's average winning margin was almost double that of the SP, its nearest rival, while both the Congress and BSP won their handful of seats by very thin margins. This means that **which party** a candidate belonged to — not their gender — was the dominant factor in determining whether they won or lost, for both men and women.

6.3 Incumbency and prior electoral experience mattered more than gender

The data also shows that sitting MLAs who recontested performed markedly better than challengers: 200 incumbents contested across all parties, of whom 143 won — a strike rate of roughly 70%, compared to just about 30% in 2017. Similarly, candidates who had contested at least one prior election consistently outperformed first-time candidates. Many of the widely reported defeated women — Asha Devi, Sadaf Jafar, Nida Ahmed, Archana Gautam, Ritu Singh, and Neha Tiwari — were first-time candidates fielded on relatively short notice, which statistically put them at a disadvantage independent of their gender.

6.4 A caveat on selection bias

The Wire's analysis notes an important caveat: parties may apply a higher bar before giving women a ticket in the first place, which could mean the women who do get tickets are, on average, stronger candidates than an unfiltered pool would be. At the same time, parties sometimes field women in constituencies they are already expected to lose, as a symbolic or token gesture. These two effects can partially offset each other, which is part of why the analysis recommends that parties become more confident about fielding a higher share of women candidates going forward, rather than treating winnability as a gender-linked concern.

Key takeaway: The data suggests most women candidates who lost in UP 2022 did so for the same reasons male candidates from the same parties lost — being on the Congress or BSP ticket in a bipolar BJP-vs-SP contest, running as first-time candidates, or contesting without an incumbency advantage — rather than because of their gender per se.

7. Detailed Reasons Behind Women's Defeats

Combining the individual candidate accounts (Section 5) with the statistical findings (Section 6), the reasons behind the defeat of most women candidates in UP 2022 can be grouped into seven themes.

7.1 A bipolar BJP-vs-SP contest squeezed out other parties

Media coverage and voter attention concentrated overwhelmingly on the BJP and SP as the only two parties with a realistic chance of forming the government. As candidate Sadaf Jafar observed, this framing meant Congress, BSP and independent candidates — including most women nominees — were not seen as serious contenders by many voters, regardless of individual merit or effort.

7.2 Weak, long-declined organisational base of Congress and BSP in UP

The Congress has had almost no functioning block- or booth-level cadre network in Uttar Pradesh for over two decades, and the BSP's traditional Dalit vote base had already been eroding toward the BJP and SP since 2014. Without local workers to convert sympathy or name-recognition into actual votes, even well-known or sympathetic candidates — a rape survivor's mother, a Miss UP titleholder, a jailed activist — struggled to build a competitive vote share.

7.3 Late nomination and very short campaign windows

Several high-profile candidates, including Asha Devi and Archana Gautam, were fielded only in the final two to three weeks before polling, leaving little time to canvass even their own assembly segment thoroughly, let alone build a full campaign machine comparable to an established local candidate's.

7.4 Candidates chosen for symbolic value, not local political strength

Congress's 'Ladki Hoon, Lad Sakti Hoon' campaign deliberately fielded women connected to causes — sexual violence survivors, CAA-protest activists, beauty-pageant winners — to make a national statement about women's representation. This raised the campaign's public profile but did not guarantee these individuals had the local caste arithmetic, family political base, or grassroots organisation that UP assembly seats typically require to win.

7.5 Consolidated caste and welfare-scheme voting patterns favoured the two main parties

The BJP consolidated support through welfare delivery (free ration, housing schemes, Ayushman Bharat health cover) combined with Hindutva-linked messaging, while the SP consolidated its traditional Yadav-Muslim and backward-caste coalition. This left a shrinking pool of voters for the Congress, BSP and independents to draw on — a pool women candidates from those parties had to share with their male colleagues.

7.6 Limited campaign funding and resources relative to party machinery

Compared to BJP and SP nominees who typically drew on established party infrastructure, funds and local strongman networks, many women contestants fielded on symbolic tickets or by smaller parties had comparatively modest campaign resources, further limiting their geographic and voter reach within a short campaign window.

7.7 Isolated, unverified allegations of irregularities

A small number of candidates, such as Nida Ahmed in Sambhal, alleged discrepancies between the votes cast by their own family and support base and the EVM count recorded at specific booths. These are individual candidate claims reported by PTI; they have not been independently verified or upheld by the Election Commission, and are included here only as part of the candidates' own public accounts of their defeat.

8. Party-by-Party Assessment

8.1 Congress (INC) — Symbolic Ambition, Structural Weakness

The Congress ran the most visible women-centric campaign of any party, fielding an estimated 148–159 women (roughly 40% of its total candidates) under the banner ‘Ladki Hoon, Lad Sakti Hoon’ and releasing a dedicated ‘Shakti Vidhaan’ manifesto with commitments such as 40% government-job reservation for women, free scooters for students, and a monthly honorarium for ASHA workers. Despite this, the party won only two seats statewide and just one through a woman candidate (Aradhana Mishra ‘Mona’, from a well-established political family in Rampur Khas). The campaign succeeded in raising the national profile of women's representation as an issue but could not overcome the party's near-total organisational collapse in the state.

8.2 Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) — Fewer Tickets, Far Higher Conversion

The BJP fielded far fewer women (45) but converted 25 of them into wins — the highest win rate (~55%) of any party. This reflects a strategy of giving winnable seats to women with existing local standing (often sitting MLAs, ministers, or candidates from politically influential families) rather than fielding large numbers as a symbolic gesture. The party's overall dominance — 255 seats won statewide — also meant its candidates of both genders benefited from the strongest campaign infrastructure and highest average winning margins in the state.

8.3 Samajwadi Party (SP) and Allies — Consolidated but Selective

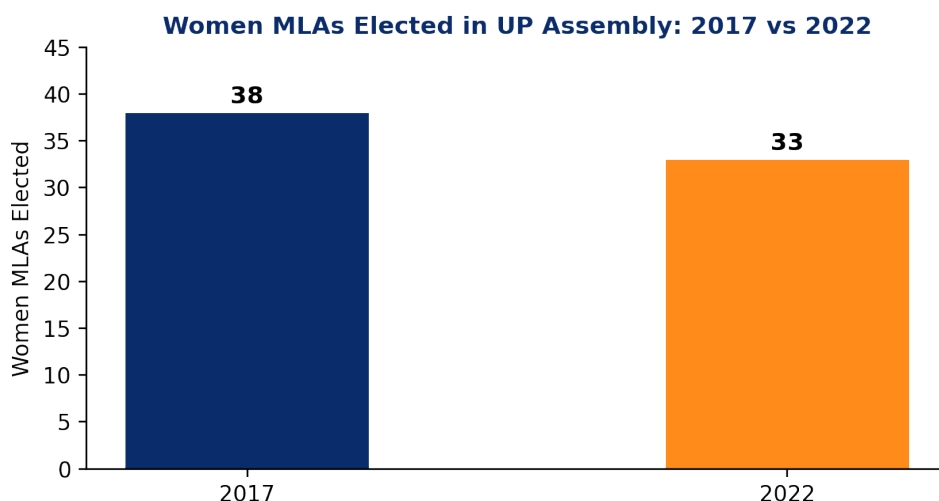
The SP-led alliance significantly increased its overall vote share compared to 2017, emerging as the principal challenger to the BJP. It fielded a comparatively modest 42 women directly and through allies, with 8–13 winning depending on how alliance partners such as Apna Dal (Soneylal) are counted. Female SP candidates performed on par with male SP candidates in vote share, consistent with the party's overall strong, caste- and community-consolidated performance in 2022.

8.4 Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) — Complete Collapse

The BSP fielded 38 women — a similar number to the BJP — but did not win a single one of those seats. This mirrors the party's overall collapse to just one seat statewide, as its core Dalit vote base fragmented toward both the BJP (particularly non-Jatav Dalits) and the SP. Notably, the data shows BSP's female candidates performed better on average than the party's own male candidates — the party's near-total defeat was a reflection of its collapsing overall vote share, not of any gender-specific weakness among its women nominees.

9. Historical Trend: 2017 vs 2022

Despite the Congress's unprecedented push to field women candidates in 2022, the total number of women elected to the UP assembly actually **declined** from 38 in 2017 to 33–34 in 2022. This underscores that simply increasing the number of women on the ballot, without also ensuring they are fielded by parties with genuine seat-winning strength in a given constituency, does not by itself improve women's representation in the legislature.



Indicator	2017	2022	Change
Women MLAs elected	38	33–34	↓ 4–5
Women's share of total seats (403)	~9.4%	~8.2–8.4%	↓
Congress women fielded (approx.)	Not comparable*	148–159	—
Congress seats won overall	7	2	↓ 5
BJP seats won overall	312	255	↓ 57

*Comparable party-wide women-candidate figures for Congress in 2017 were not consistently reported in available sources; the party fielded a much smaller share of women that year, prior to Priyanka Gandhi Vadra's 40%-ticket pledge introduced ahead of 2022.

2017 was itself notable as the first UP assembly election in which women crossed 10% representation (women held 40 of 403 seats at the start of that assembly, following some post-poll changes); 2022's dip to 33–34 represents a step backward on that metric even as national and state discourse around women's political representation intensified.

10. Conclusion & Recommendations

The 2022 Uttar Pradesh election data tells a more nuanced story than a simple narrative of women candidates underperforming. Where women were fielded by parties with genuine ground strength and winnable seats (BJP, and to a lesser extent SP), they won at rates comparable to, or better than, their male colleagues. Where women were fielded predominantly as a symbolic gesture by structurally weak parties (Congress, BSP), they lost — for the same structural reasons their male colleagues in those parties also lost.

10.1 For political parties

- Prioritise giving women tickets in constituencies where the party already has organisational strength and a realistic path to victory, rather than using women's candidacies primarily as a symbolic or national messaging device in unwinnable seats.
- Where a candidate is fielded primarily for her personal story or public profile (survivors, activists, public figures), pair the nomination with early announcement and dedicated ground-level campaign support, since late nomination was a repeated factor in several high-profile defeats.
- Invest in rebuilding booth- and block-level organisational infrastructure in constituencies where the party's presence has eroded, since this affects the electoral prospects of all candidates — not only women.

10.2 For future analysis and transparency

- Election Commission and ADR/myneta.info data should continue to be published in a form that allows full constituency-wise, gender-disaggregated analysis of both winning and losing candidates, to allow this kind of assessment to be extended beyond the high-profile cases covered here.
- Future reports on women's electoral performance should control for party affiliation and incumbency status before drawing conclusions about gender-linked 'winnability', given how much of the variance in the 2022 results is explained by these two factors rather than gender itself.

Scope note: This report profiles six extensively documented defeated candidates and provides aggregate, party-wise data for all others. Full constituency-wise vote, opponent and margin data for every one of the roughly 520+ defeated women candidates across all parties exists in ECI and myneta.info records, but compiling each one individually was outside the scope of this report. A more granular breakdown for a specific party, region or set of constituencies can be compiled separately on request.

11. Sources & Methodology Notes

This report draws on the following primary sources:

- **myneta.info** (Association for Democratic Reforms / ADR) — “Uttar Pradesh 2022 Election: Total women winners” and individual candidate affidavit pages, sourced from the Election Commission of India (ECI).
- **PTI / The Hawk** — “UP Polls: Only 1 Of 148 Women Candidates Of Congress Won” (20 April 2022), the primary source for the six defeated-candidate profiles in Section 5.
- **The Wire** — Fahad Hasin, “A Bipolar Contest Where Candidates Mattered: What Data Says About the UP Results” (18 March 2022), the primary source for the statistical analysis in Section 6.
- **Wikipedia** — individual constituency and candidate pages (e.g. Anjula Singh Mahaur, Alka Singh Arkvanshi, Surabhi Singh, Swati Singh, Rajeshwar Singh), cross-checked against ECI-sourced results.
- **Navbharat Times, Amar Ujala, Drishti IAS** — aggregate party-wise ticket and win figures for women candidates.

Where different sources reported slightly different totals (e.g. Congress women candidates variously reported as 148 or 155–159; total women MLAs as 33 or 34), this report has presented the range rather than forcing a single figure, and flagged the discrepancy in the relevant table footnote.

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